INNOVATING IN LIBRARIES

Surviving Technological Lethargy in Times of Endless Transformation

VOLUME 1



Edited by

BLESSING CHIPARAUSHA
COLLENCE TAKAINGENHAMO CHISITA
MADELEINE FOMBAD

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Innovating in Libraries, Volume 1

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The global librarianship community will benefit immensely from reading this, because the topics covered in the book reflects current trends in the global library information ecosystem. Likewise, the main motif of book can be generalized to the broader global society, because emphasis is placed on the current dynamics in the information landscape considering the proliferation of emerging technologies. The multitude of topics studied are relate to the present and the future and they provide theoretical and practical basis for each topicincluded in the book. The outputs are terrific because they explore in depth and breadth hot button topics with practical examples drawn from different parts of the world and solutions that are tried and tested for the benefit of key stakeholders, in the scholarly communication value-chain. There are several ways to assess the book's usefulness. First, by calculating the quantitative impact of the quotations included in each chapter. Second, by evaluating the qualitative impact, which may be gauged by the studies' reproducibility and output consistency across various methodological implementations, as well as the degree to which the outcomes add to the advantages the emerging technologies provide to society.

***—Professor Juan Miguel Palma Peña,* PhD, Library and Information Science, Humanities Coordination, Biblioteca, National Autonomous University of Mexico (Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México, UNAM), Mexico**

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Innovating in Libraries, Volume 1: Surviving Technological Lethargy in Times of Endless Transformation

EDITED BY

BLESSING CHIPARAUSHA
Bindura University of Science Education, Zimbabwe

COLLENCE TAKAINGENHAMO CHISITA
Durban University of Technology, South Africa

AND

MADELEINE FOMBAD
University of South Africa, South Africa



United Kingdom – North America – Japan – India – Malaysia – China

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INVESTOR IN PEOPLE

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On a sombre note, the editorial team and contributors wish to express heartfelt condolences on the passing of Mrs Christiana O. Onifade, a supervisee of Dr Alice B. Bamigbola from the Department of School Library and Media Technology at the University of Ibadan, Nigeria. She passed away on 27 March 2025, and we are deeply saddened by the untimely loss. It is worth noting that prior to her passing, she and her supervisor had jointly submitted two captivating abstracts under the following titles:

(1) Echo Chambers in the Classroom: The Role of Social Media in Shaping Students' Academic Perspectives
(2) The Rise of Edutainment: Analysing Educational Podcasts' Role in Lifelong Learning

Out of the aforementioned abstracts, unfortunately, only the first one was submitted as a full chapter after undergoing a series of reviews and corrections until it was finally submitted for the book. We would like to express our heartfelt condolences to her family and friends, the Nigerian Library Association, and the library fraternity in Africa and the whole world. We salute and honour her steadfast commitment to library and information science practice and education. The deceased's love for wisdom, cooperation, and collaboration should inspire many of us and future generations. We draw lessons from her that 'one hand cannot embrace the fig tree', but when we put our efforts together, we achieve greater things. No matter where we are, we can make positive change for the betterment of the world and humanity. May Her Dear Soul Rest in Eternal Peace.

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About the Editors

Blessing Chiparausha is University Librarian at Bindura University of Science Education, Zimbabwe. He holds a PhD in Information Science from the University of South Africa. He has published refereed journal articles, book chapters, and conference papers on the use of information and communication technologies in academic libraries, mainly focusing on the use of social media, free and open-source software, and related digital applications (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-0583-6945).

Collence Takaingenhamo Chisita holds a PhD in Library and Information Science (LIS). He has worked with the Department of Information Science at the University of South Africa in Pretoria, and currently, he is based at the Durban University of Technology, South Africa, in the Department of Information Systems. He is an editor, writer, researcher, and lecturer. He has been Secretary for the International Federation of Library Associations and Institutions. Indigenous Matters Section from 2021 to 2023 and currently he is a Standing Committee Member for the section. He is also Secretary for the African Library and Information Associations and Institutions (AFLIA) Library Education and Training Section. In May 2025, at a conference in Windhoek, Namibia, he was the first recipient of the AFLIA Open Scholarship and Open Science award for scientific excellence. In addition, he received the South African National Research Foundation C2 award from 2023 to 2028 in appreciation of his contributions to LIS and associated scientific research (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-7375-8627).

Madeleine Fombad is a Professor at the Department of Information Science at University of South Africa. Her broad research interest lies in knowledge management, knowledge management for sustainable development, knowledge management education, information communication technologies, and open access in libraries. She focuses on producing high-impact research that contributes to societal problems, realising the sustainable development goals, enhancing development in the field of information science, and improving the life of the community. She has written numerous journal articles, book chapters, and coauthored and coedited numerous publications with reputable publishers (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0003-4665-1354).

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About the Contributors

Mary Acanit is a Librarian and Head, Library Information Communication Technologies Section at Kyambogo University in Uganda. She holds a PhD in Information Science from the University of South Africa. She has more than 14 years of professional library practice, mainly in academic library settings. Her research interests span from library automation to digital libraries, human information behaviour, information literacy, research support, open science, and transdisciplinary research. She is a librarian, trainer, and research advocate. She currently serves on the Research and Publications Functional Committee of the Consortium of Uganda University Libraries (ORCID: https://orcid.org/my-orcid?orcid=0000-0001-6112-0071).

Yusuf Ayodeji Ajani is a Lecturer at the University of Abuja, Federal Capital Territory, Nigeria. He is a Certified Librarian of Nigeria and an active member of several professional organisations, including the Nigerian Library Association, the Nigerian Association of Library and Information Science Educators, and the Association for Information Science and Technology. His research focuses on Fourth Industrial Revolution skills, green libraries, emerging technologies in libraries, and Indigenous knowledge systems (ORCID: http://orcid.org/0000-0002-2786-4461).

Oluwatosin Daniel Akobe is a dynamic librarian, educator, and digital innovator passionate about transforming libraries through technology and inclusion. With a Master's in Library and Information Technology from the Federal University of Technology, Minna, Nigeria, he lectures at Kogi State College of Education, Ankpa, where he also serves as the E-librarian. He is also an Adjunct Lecturer with Abubakar Tafawa Balewa University, Bauchi, Nigeria, in the Department of Library and Information Science. A published author and conference speaker, his work explores the integration of artificial intelligence in library services, digital preservation, and equitable access to information. He is a certified librarian and an active member of national and international professional bodies. He is also a reviewer for national and international journals. His career blends academic excellence with practical impact, advancing the future of libraries in Africa's evolving knowledge environment (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0001-5772-3216).

Alice A. Bamigbola is a Certified Librarian of Nigeria and a Senior Lecturer specialising in digital libraries, institutional repositories, and information and

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knowledge management. She lectures in the Department of School Library and Media Technology at the University of Ibadan, Ibadan, Nigeria, where she focuses on the integration of information and communication technologies in library science. She holds a PhD in Library and Information Studies from the University of Ibadan, along with a Bachelor's degree in Library and Information Studies, a Master's in Personnel Psychology, and an International Master's in Digital Library Learning from former Oslo University College now Oslo Metropolitan University Norway. An Erasmus Mundus Scholar, her research interests include digital libraries, E-learning, literacies, information and knowledge management, and school librarianship. She is recognised for her contributions to advancing the use of technology in scholarly communication and library services.

Petros Nhlavu Dlamini (PhD) is a Senior Lecturer in the Department of Information Studies in the Faculty of Humanities and Social Sciences at the University of Zululand, South Africa. He holds a PhD and MLIS in Library and Information Science from the University of Zululand in 2016 and 2004. He has published several papers in accredited journals and book chapters. He has supervised several master's and PhD students to completion in the domain. His research interests encompass Indigenous knowledge, knowledge management, information retrieval, cataloguing and classification, information communication technologies for development, and customer care in libraries (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-0014-419X).

Sylvester I. Ebhonu is a Certified Librarian in Nigeria who currently heads Faculty and Satellite Campus Libraries at Admiralty University of Nigeria, Ibusa. He is pursuing a PhD in Library and Information Science at Delta State University, Abraka. With over 12 years of experience in capacity building, library administration, and consultancy, he actively serves the Nigerian Library Association; he is an Associate Member of the Practical Artificial Intelligence Development Foundation, and a member of other professional bodies. He is recognised within the profession as The Digital Librarian for leading several initiatives championing digital transformation, artificial intelligence literacy, and professional recognition across Africa (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-1006-453X).

Rexwhite Tega Enakrire is an enthusiastic Researcher and Associate Professor at the University of Johannesburg, College of Business and Economics, South Africa. He holds a PhD, MSc, PGDE, BSc, and Diploma in Library and Information Science. He has attended several international and national conferences. He has worked in different universities in Nigeria, South Africa and the United States. His research interests include academic librarianship, IKM, ICT4D/AI/Digital Technologies, HCI (UX), health informatics, and bibliometrics/scientometrics. He has published over 100 articles and 9 book chapters in accredited journals and conference proceedings (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0001-6523-5669).

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Panorea Gaitanou holds a PhD in Archives, Library Science, and Museology from the Ionian University of Greece, complemented by an MSc in Information Science. She's currently an Archivist at the General State Archives of Greece (since September 2024). She also served as Head Librarian at the Hellenic National Defense College (2020–2024) and the Benaki Museum Library (2002–2015). With around 70 publications, she is a prolific researcher, showcasing her deep expertise in library and archival science (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0003-2155-4603).

Wangwe Isimail Gutaka is a Computer Technician and Educator at Kyambogo University Library with over a decade of experience in information communication technology support and academic libraries. He holds a BSc in Information Technology and a Diploma in Computer Science. His expertise spans digital libraries, institutional repositories, and emerging technologies. He provides information communication technology infrastructure support, research supervision, and training to staff and students. He is passionate about enhancing education through technology and fostering access to information. He speaks multiple languages and enjoys reading, internet research, and community engagement (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0009-0009-6288-6437).

Kingsley N. Igwe a PhD holder in Library and Information Science and Associate Professor at Federal University of Technology Minna, Minna, Nigeria. He has published numerous journal articles and book chapters in accredited journals (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0001-5636-002X).

Tom Kwanya is a Professor and Knowledge Management Specialist with several years of practical work experience in the East, West, South, and Horn of Africa regions. He has also taught knowledge and information management as well as technology-mediated communication in public and private universities in Kenya. He is a published author of several refereed journal articles, conference papers, edited book chapters, and two monographs. His research interests are library innovations and knowledge management (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-6306-2669).

Amina Badaru Lukman is a Librarian at Baze University, Abuja, Nigeria. She holds a master's degree from Federal University of Technology, Minna, Niger State. She has published journal articles, book chapters, and conference papers on areas in librarianship in which she has a flair. Her areas of interest include, but are not limited to, records and archival studies, user studies, bibliometrics, etc. (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0001-9596-7019).

Rosemary Maturure is a distinguished University Librarian at Africa University in Mutare, Zimbabwe, with a career spanning over 25 years in both school, special, and academic libraries. Since 1996, she has dedicated her professional life to enhancing the educational landscape through effective library services and innovative research support. She has published articles, book chapters, and a book (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-1245-5358).

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Braiton U. Mukhalela is a Zimbabwean computer scientist and educator with over 15 years of experience in academia, artificial intelligence research, and software development. He holds master's and bachelor's degrees and is currently studying towards his PhD. His career spans information technology roles at CSIR-Meraka in South Africa and Soft-Systems as a Developer; now he is working as a Data Engineer/Analyst in the WEATHER Project at UKZN (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0009-0006-8075-7565).

Edward Mukiibi is a Senior Librarian at Kyambogo University, a position he has held since 2012. He heads the Technical Services Section, which is responsible for collection development and access to library resources. He has been at the forefront of implementing the Koha Integrated Library System at the University Library. He is pursuing a PhD in Library and Information Science at Makerere University, the East African School of Library and Information Science. His research interests are in research data management and library leadership and management (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0003-0350-5808).

Grace Mutsvunguma is a Postdoctoral Research Fellow at the University of South Africa. She has worked as an Academic Librarian in Universities in Zimbabwe and South Africa. She has also published numerous journal articles in the South African Department of Higher Education and Training list of accredited journals. Her research interests focus on the interplay between emerging technologies and libraries (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-8007-6632).

Dalitso Mvula is the Chief Librarian at Lusaka Apex Medical University in Zambia. He holds a double major Bachelor's degree in Library and Information Science and Development Studies and a Master's in Library and Information Science from the University of Zambia. Previously, he was a Senior Librarian for Livingstone International University for Tourism Excellence and Business Management. He has also worked for First Quantum Minerals Limited as a Human Resources Clerk under the registry. His research interests are Indigenous knowledge, artificial intelligence, knowledge management, and library management (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-8930-1496).

Bolaji David Oladokun is an enthusiastic Researcher and Lecturer at the Federal University of Technology, Ikot Abasi, Akwa Ibom State, Nigeria. He holds a First-class degree in Library and Information Science and a Diploma in Mass Communication with distinction. He earned his Master's degree in Library and Information Science from Ignatius Ajuru University of Education, Port Harcourt, Nigeria, graduating with distinction. Certified by the Librarians' Registration Council of Nigeria, he is an active member of the Nigerian Library Association, the Nigerian Association of Library and Information Science Educators, and the Association for Information Science and Technology. Serving as the Business Editor of the *Rivers State NLA Journal*, he has authored several articles in accredited journals, conference proceedings, and book chapters. He also served as a reviewer for numerous journals indexed in *Scopus, Scimago*,

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and *Web of Science*. Additionally, he has published three books and edited two book chapters in the field of library and information science (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-7826-9187).

Christianah O. Onifade was an Educationist and a Doctoral student in the Department of School Library and Media Technology, University of Ibadan, Ibadan, Nigeria. She co-authored the chapter with her supervisor, Dr Alice A. Bamigbola. She had her Bachelor's degree in Computer Science and her Master's degree in Educational Media Technology from the University of Ibadan, Ibadan, Nigeria.

Kareem Abdulraheem Onivehu is a trained librarian and information specialist with several years of experience in civic engagement, public sector, health, and education. He is passionate about youth development, specifically the development needs of vulnerable and marginalised youths. He has served as Secretary, Public Relations Officer, and Programme Team Lead to several groups such as the Young African Leaders Initiative Network Kogi, World Institute for Peace Kogi branch, and Cal-Maji Foundation; Volunteer at TEDx Adankolo, TEDx Ganaja, TEDx Adankolo 2, Confluence Intellectual Convergence and Development Initiative, Bridge Inspire Foundation, and Heritage and Legacy Foundation; Chairman Education Committee NYCN Kogi branch, and has taken part in the implementation of several community-oriented initiatives. He is an Alumnus of the United States Government-funded YALI Regional Leadership Fellowship for Emerging Young Leaders in West Africa with a track record in Business and Entrepreneurship, a finalist of the DOW/YALI RLC West Africa, Accra Design Challenge in Sustainable Management. He loves learning, travelling, and meeting people, and is a registered member with the Librarian Registration Council of Nigeria. He is at present the Programme Manager at Hemam Synergy Nigeria Limited, Ibaji operation and holds a Master's degree in Library and Information Technology from Federal University of Technology Minna, Niger State (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0009-0003-1560-1327).

Edmont Pasipamire is an accomplished Information Specialist and an emerging Researcher with a Master's degree in Information Communication Technology in Information Science from the University of Pretoria (2023). He also holds a Bachelor of Science Honours degree in Psychology from Zimbabwe Open University (2013) and a National Diploma in Library and Information Science from Harare Polytechnic (1998). Additionally, he earned a Certificate in Scientific and Information Management from Vrije Universiteit of Brussels, Belgium (2005). He is currently employed at Rosebank College, Cape Town Campus. His research interests include eResearch, Technostress, Computer Vision Syndrome, sustainable development, and the integration of artificial intelligence in library and information services. He was also nominated as a finalist for the Library and Information Association of South Africa Librarian Research Award 2024 and the Rosebank College Research Excellency Award 2024 (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0001-7552-5168).

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Adeyinka Tella is a Professor and Head of Department at the Department of Library and Information Science at the University of Ilorin in Nigeria and he is currently a distinguished Professor at the University of South Africa in Pretoria, South Africa. He is a dedicated researcher who has won so many research accolades. He has published numerous journal articles, book chapters, and authored and edited numerous books with accredited publishers (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0002-5382-4471).

Stephen Tsekea lectures in the Department of Information Science and Records Management of the Zimbabwe Open University. He holds professional qualifications as follows: Master's in Business Leadership, MSc in Library and Information Science, BSc in Library and Information Science, and Postgraduate Diploma in Tertiary Education. His research interests are in artificial intelligence, knowledge management, higher education, innovation, libraries, and customer care. He has written a number of journal articles and book chapters. Some of his publications have focused on artificial intelligence in libraries and schools, scholarly publishing, mental health, youth violence, inclusive education, and space design in libraries. He has also presented at local and international library conferences (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0000-0003-2885-2515).

Lincoln Samuel Wamala is the Systems Librarian at Kyambogo University, Uganda. He supports the University's digital library infrastructure and works directly with the Integrated Library Management System (Koha). He has vast knowledge and experience in Koha installation, configuration, and customisation. He also holds a Master of Science in Information Science from Makerere University, Uganda. His research interests include: integrated library management systems, institutional repositories, artificial intelligence, digital literacy, free and open-source software, and library automation (ORCID: https://orcid.org/0009-0002-0436-623X).

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Foreword

The question of how new technologies transform libraries is as old as the technological revolutions themselves. Each wave of innovation – ranging from the advent of electronic databases and integrated library management systems to the Internet, Web 2.0, and the rise of social media platforms – has prompted scholars and practitioners to ask whether libraries should embrace or resist technological change. Yet, the central challenge lies elsewhere. The real issue is not whether to accept or reject new technologies, but rather whether libraries and librarians will remain passive objects of technological (r)evolution or act as proactive subjects, shaping their own destinies. In other words, should new technologies be perceived as existential threats or as opportunities to design new services, strengthen their societal role, and redefine their missions?

The two volumes of *Innovating in Libraries: Surviving Technological Lethargy in Times of Endless Transformation* respond to this question by presenting a unified call for libraries to actively engage with disruptive technologies while reimagining their role in the digital age. Volume 1 emphasises practical applications, such as artificial intelligence (AI), chatbots, integrated systems, spatial redesign, and cloud computing. Volume 2, by contrast, places greater weight on governance, ethics, open science, research data management, and strategic planning. Together, they make the case that libraries must combine technological adoption with ethical frameworks, user-centred design, and collaborative partnerships in order to remain relevant and sustainable in the Fourth Industrial Revolution.

The contributions, which include both empirical case studies – particularly from African and Asian academic libraries – and more conceptual or policy-oriented chapters, offer a comprehensive, multidisciplinary, and global perspective on the challenges and opportunities that confront libraries worldwide. A recurring theme is the question of acceptance, namely the perceived usefulness and ease of use of technological innovations, for both librarians and their patrons. What value do these new tools and services add to existing library functions? How do they affect the quality of service provision, and what transformations do they imply for librarians' professional identities and skills?

Two interrelated concerns emerge from this reflection. First, the human resources dimension: future librarianship will require advanced information communication technology skills, continuous training, and the ability to adapt rapidly to evolving technologies. Several chapters highlight how technological innovations are already reshaping librarians' roles, responsibilities, and relationships with users and institutional partners. Second, the mission of the library

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itself comes into question. For centuries, libraries were defined by their roles in collecting, preserving, and disseminating knowledge across multiple media. Today, in the age of large-scale digital repositories and generative AI, these functions are increasingly mediated by algorithmic processes. What does it mean for the library's mission and for the profession, for instance, if metadata enrichment or user recommendations are provided not by trained professionals but by AI systems?

Other central issues explored in the volumes include user-centred services, accessibility, responsive design in dynamic learning environments, and governance. Both volumes converge on the conclusion that libraries face what has been described as 'choiceless choices': to adapt through innovation, collaboration, and proactive engagement, or risk marginalisation and irrelevance. Critical reflections throughout the volumes seek to balance opportunities with risks, stressing the importance of ethical frameworks, inclusivity, sustainability, and the support of institutions and policymakers. This raises another fundamental question: do libraries possess the necessary resources – in terms of budgets, staffing, infrastructure, and political support – to meet the challenges posed by rapid technological change?

Ultimately, the title of the work encapsulates its main message: *Innovating Libraries* is underpinned by the conviction that libraries, and particularly academic libraries, are not doomed to suffer technological change passively. Rather, they must assert themselves as active agents and drivers of innovation. This dual challenge – embracing new technologies while simultaneously rethinking workflows, services, and societal roles – is at the heart of the volumes' argument.

This collective work, authored by more than 40 scholars, librarians, and information professionals, combines practical insights with critical reflection and presents a diverse array of case studies. Its breadth and depth make it a significant contribution and a valuable companion for the ongoing transformation of libraries worldwide.

Joachim Schöpfel (ORCID: 0000-0002-4000-807X)
Associate Professor Emeritus in Information and Communication Sciences at the University of Lille, Sciences de l'information et de la communication, France

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Preface

Libraries of all types are at the epicentre of a technological storm, and disruptive technologies have come in handy to leverage such institutions to leap forward into the turbulent future. The progress of libraries, irrespective of their type, depends on their ability to adapt to the changing information landscape. According to Fombad et al. (2025), libraries of all kinds have an option to either give up or continue in spite of all obstacles, arguing that they are not an exception to the current technological developments in the infosphere. In the same artery of intellectual discourse, Khomo et al. (2023) and Tammaro (2024) argued that in order to meet the evolving information needs of users who are more techno-savvy and prefer remote access to information, academic libraries are adopting emerging technology and modifying their traditional services and routines. Libraries, by nature, are key towers of the infosphere, hence, their unquestionable role in initiating and marshalling technological progression. Referencing Boulding (1970), Fombad et al. (2025) portrayed as a radically dynamic, complex, and innovative environment supported by the rapidly evolving digital technology. Libraries hold a prominent position in the information environment because they are forerunners in technological progress and credible sources in preferring to epistemological issues affecting users. Disruptive technologies and how they are transforming libraries in the 21st century are at the heart of the book. In general, any invention that profoundly changes our previous methods and upends them is referred to as disruptive technology (Al-Fugaha et al., 2024; Alsaraireh et al., 2022). The aforementioned authors point out that the genesis of disruptive technology classically shapes up from a millimetric to a colossal gauge but progressively blowouts and unseats more legacy technologies and work models. Disruptive technologies encapsulate an array of emerging technologies including, but not limited to artificial intelligence (AI), big data, blockchain, nanotechnology, virtual reality, cloud computing, the internet of things, and online education among many other technologies.

The book's recurring themes are justified by the authors' diverse backgrounds, who argue that the decision of whether to embrace or reject disruptive technology is a Hobson option, or what Langer (1982) called 'choiceless choices'. The only way out of this unstable situation is for libraries to re-evaluate, restart, and re-plan as they navigate the transition to technological advancements because the evens outweigh the odds.

Together, the book's effulgent authors – who hail from Africa, Europe, and Asia – have done a fantastic job of shedding light on how libraries can overcome

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technological sluggishness and maximise the use of disruptive technologies. The authors' contributions add up the quantum of intellectual discourse by weaving a tapestry of articles that advance the corpus of knowledge in library and information science and related disciplines. The topics covered in this book include, disruptive technologies, integrated library management systems (ILMS), social media use and seduction, library and information science (LIS) education and training, edutainment, computer vision syndrome (CVS), quantum cloud computing, spatial configurations, emerging technologies, library user experiences in dynamic spaces, digital transformation, open scholarship, open science, collaboration and partnerships, research ecosystems, research data systems, research data management (and data policies), and electronic library experience among others. With such a wealth of intellectual gravitas, the book is set to make a significant digital footprint in the LIS landscape, and its value or significance can never be doubted.

The book commences with a scintillating and captivating introduction that illuminates the highly pitched intellectual realm and discourse collaboratively sculptured by the editors drawing insights from the effulgent author's contributions. It signals the trajectory of the narratives, creates expectations, and gives crucial background information about the fascinating intellectual treatise and its standing as a book for anyone seeking to expand their mind through engaging discourse on current trends in library infosphere. Using a Schumpeter approach or lens the introduction weaves a tapestry of motifs that justify the critical role of the book regarding the need for positive and progressive technical progress in academic libraries in an era of constant change.

Chapter 1 delves into the effects of disruptive technologies in Kenya's academic libraries. Using theoretical triangulation, the researcher weaves a rich tapestry of a qualitative study to explore how digital transformation has been spurred by digital technological advancements in the 21st-century history of academic libraries in Kenya. By use of qualitative data collection and analysis tools, the researcher excavates, analyses, and synthesises key findings that reveal humongous development in the technological developments of academic libraries in Kenya. To spruce and conclude the study, the researcher proffers praxis-oriented solutions to enhance the digital transformation trajectory already in motion at a splendid speed.

The subsequent Chapter 2 takes a well-calculated and precise dug up into the systematic process of installing, customising, and upgrading of Koha Integrated Library System (ILS) at Kyambogo University in Uganda. Using work experience, the researchers provide a well-articulated step-by-step excursion in the implementation of Koha. The implementation process is vividly and systematically reflected by the key highlights, namely installation, configuration, data migration, and staff training. The study raises key issues regarding the steps to be followed, the software, institutional support, and staff competencies key to the successful implementation of the Koha ILS and leverage its capabilities for electronic content management.

Chapter 3 unpacks and analyses the factors affecting the adoption of chatbots to respond to users' queries in academic libraries. Rallying under the clarion

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call for technological survival in the era of disruptive technologies, the chapter emphasises the dire need for libraries to embrace novel technologies in an era of constant change. By extolling the virtues of chatbots, the chapter heightens the imperative for libraries to adopt such technologies for the benefit of users. Using a narrative literature review the chapter, examines and interrogates the historical evolution of chatbots, and perception of chatbots as replacements for human interaction, security and privacy concerns, and lastly cultural attitudes towards these technologies.

Following the same trend regarding technological adoption, Chapter 4 maintains the momentum by exploring the role of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) in Enhancing Education and Learning Outcomes. Using a case study approach, the chapter explores the multifaceted role of GenAI in education, focusing on its ability to personalise learning experiences, foster collaboration, and support educators. While the focus is on examining case studies illustrating the successful integration of GenAI in various educational contexts, highlighting measurable improvements in student motivation, performance, and accessibility. At the same time, the chapter strikes a balance by critically evaluating the challenges and limitations associated with GenAI implementation, including concerns about bias, equity, data privacy, and potential job displacement in the education sector.

The Chapter 5 maintains the same thread in the artery of discourse shifts focus to a critical examination of the lessons and implications derived from South African universities with regard to Artificial Intelligence and its intersection with global trends in academic libraries. Using a literature review methodology, the study explores global trends in the use of AI in public academic libraries, analyses the tools implemented by academic libraries in South African public universities, and offers recommendations based on best practices for better-quality implementation. Data were gathered through the analysis of university websites, policy frameworks, and published literature. A comparative approach was used to evaluate global trends alongside local practices, enabling the identification of key AI functions, frameworks guiding AI implementation and the common challenges. The chapter provides an intriguing original study in its focused examination of AI's impact on South African public academic libraries, while combining insights on global AI tool adoption with specific local examples.

In Chapter 6, social media and the formation of academic echo chambers takes centre stage as the researchers delve into how social media shapes academic discourse by fostering echo chambers digital spaces that reinforces ideological homogeneity and limits exposure to diverse viewpoints. Using a narrative literature review drawing on both conceptual frameworks and empirical studies, the review addresses the key objectives regarding social media usage. The findings of the study exposes how algorithmic filtering amplifies confirmation bias, narrows academic perspectives, and undermines critical dialogue in learning environments. The researchers raise the clarion call for intentional pedagogical interventions such as media literacy education, dialogic teaching practices, and algorithmic transparency that disrupt echo chamber effects and promote a more inclusive, reflective, and critically engaged learning environment.

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Chapter 7 continues the discussion on AI by focusing on its acceptance and use among academic librarians in Zambia and Zimbabwe. The research indicates that academic librarians in both countries exhibit a mixed response to AI, demonstrating both enthusiasm and reservations. While acknowledging AI's potential benefits, the academic librarians also express concerns about potential job displacement. Therefore, the chapter concludes by recommending comprehensive training programmes to equip academic librarians with the necessary skills to effectively integrate and leverage AI in their roles.

Subsequently, Chapter 8 shifts focus towards exploring spatial configurations for repurposing library space to enhance learning experiences in Zimbabwean University Libraries. Using a case study approach, the chapter calls for the repurposing of library spaces in sync with technological developments. It calls for novel spatial designs that reshape the architectural designs of both physical and digital library. The chapter argues that rethinking space repurposing in academic libraries will attract more users in sync with the dynamic and complex needs of the 21st century patron. The chapter provides a justification for repurposing library space in response to the needs of the increasingly diverse student population in higher education and the role of technology in creating all-inclusive spaces.

Chapter 9 explores the strategies for long-term engagement for the cultivation of sustainable communities and research partnerships in the shifting sands of technical progress. The chapter argues that in times of rapid and disruptive technical progress it is imperative to establish long-lasting research collaborations between government, business, academia, and local communities. The researchers bring to the limelight how sustainable community and research partnership can be strategically repositioned for long-term engagement and collaboration. An overview of research on the value of open communication, trust, shared objectives, and long-term relationship building in partnerships is succinctly examined. The other aspect brought to the fore in the treatise includes cooperate as the new competition in the collaborative academic landscape. Finally, a novel framework for sustaining community-research partnerships, integrating co-creation processes, resource allocation, and trust-building, providing actionable awareness for practitioners, policymakers, and academics in collaborative initiatives, is proffered.

Chapter 10 takes a futuristic stance by meticulously analysing the skills and competencies essential for the sustainability of the Library and Information Science profession in Nigeria. The genesis of the chapter zeros in on the current state of the LIS field in Nigeria and its experiences with emerging technologies, namely AI and correlated digital advancements. At the core of the chapter are the crucial skills and competencies necessary for librarians to adjust to the dynamic digital environment and sustain the LIS profession. Using a survey research, the chapter probes the experiences of the LIS professionals in academic libraries throughout North Central Nigeria in an era of technological ingenuity. A number of issues are raised by the chapter including the importance of ongoing professional development and curriculum revisions to include advanced Information Communication Technology skills, ensuring that librarians stay pertinent in the digital era.

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The chapter adds significant praxis-oriented contributions regarding the current discourse about the future of libraries in the face of swift technological progress.

Chapter 11 provides an intriguing exploration of the prevalence, health impacts, and management strategies of CVS among librarians, considering that digital devices are the *sine qua non tools* of the trade. The chapter delves into the less explored terrain of CVS. The underlying question guiding the chapter is 'How prevalent is CVS among librarians, what are its health and occupational impacts, and which interventions are most effective in mitigating its effects?' Using a systematic review approach, the chapter explores how CVS affects librarians. Furthermore, the study reveals that CVS not only poses significant physical and mental health risks but also adversely affects job performance, contributing to fatigue and occupational stress. The chapter provides recommendations aligned to ergonomic interventions such as adjustable desks, anti-glare screens, and enhanced lighting, as well as behavioural strategies like regular screen breaks and adherence to the 20–20–20 rule. The chapter extols the value of integrated intervention approaches in reducing the impact of CVS.

Chapter 12 delves into the potential of quantum cloud computing in managing big data in academic libraries. Using an interpretative content analysis to review literature from databases such as Scopus, Web of Science, and Google Scholar, assess the opportunities and challenges that quantum cloud computing provides to libraries. The findings of the study reveal that quantum cloud computing holds momentous latency for revolutionising big data management in libraries. With an indomitable academic spirit, the study maintains that quantum cloud computing offers faster data processing, more efficient storage solutions, and advanced data analytics that enable libraries to manage vast datasets with increased accuracy and speed. A composed overview regarding the advantages and disadvantages of quantum cloud computing. Being a pioneering study, the authors raise fundamental points regarding the potential of quantum cloud computing for libraries. The study offers valuable insights into how libraries can address existing challenges and harness the unique capabilities of quantum cloud computing to enhance big data management.

The conclusion nudges the reader's memory through summarising the key motifs of the book and its significance to scientific studies on *Innovating in Libraries: Surviving Technological Lethargy in Times of Endless Transformation*'. It succinctly binds together key points and illustrates the broader meaning of technical progress among libraries at a time when the pace of disruptive or creative technologies is accelerating at a pace that is unimaginable. As they move towards a technologically driven future where important evidence-based decisions regarding technology adoption must be made before it's too late, the editorial team reiterates the crucial role of technology and the necessity for libraries to be futuristic and Schumpeterian (2013) regarding innovation and progress.

The book exemplifies the dialectical progression of how disruptive technologies have metamorphosed into the conventional and futuristic existential and survival modes of operation that characterise the novel frontiers of the dynamic infosphere. Critical information issues and research lacunas are responded to by the authors using praxis-based and evidence-based solutions. The onus is upon

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the LIS fraternity, including educators and practitioners, policymakers, and key stakeholders, to embrace the book as an added value to the discipline and the profession. This will be a befitting honour and accolade to the editors and the effulgent or incandescent authors for their sterling contributions to the momentous book.

(1) Blessing Chiparausha (Dr), Bindura University of Science Education, Zimbabwe
(2) Collence Takaingenhamo Chisita (Dr), Department of Information Systems, Durban University of Technology, South Africa
(3) Madeleine Fombad (Prof.), Department of Information Science, University of South Africa

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